from East Pakistan in less than 100 days after mid-April, and India's Border Security Force started providing some arms and training to Bangladeshi rebels (the Mukti Fauj, later Mukti Bahini), Indira Gandhi resisted military intervention. War plans were drafted by the Army only in the summer of 1971 and finalized in October. [8]

The international environment also played a role, most notably the US–China rapprochement engineered in July 1971 during Henry Kissinger's visit to China via Pakistan. Already, in mid-June 1971, Indian leaders had begun contemplating a Treaty of Peace and Friendship with the Soviet Union. Foreign Secretary T.N. Kaul, in fact, suggested that India offer similar treaties to the United States and Afghanistan, a notion rejected by Secretary to the Prime Minister P.N. Haksar. Indira Gandhi even suggested discussing such as agreement with China, with whom India's relationship was still frosty. [9] But these considerations were overtaken by news of Henry Kissinger's visit to Pakistan in July and the United States' tilt towards Pakistan and China.

Kissinger made it clear to Indian diplomats that the US would not help if China intervened in an India–Pakistan war. Haksar, Kaul, and D.P. Dhar accelerated outreach efforts to the Soviet Union, which after 1965 had begun to project itself as a neutral broker in South Asia and had even supplied arms to Pakistan in 1968. After lengthy negotiations, New Delhi and Moscow signed the Indo–Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation on 9 August. The treaty ensured that the USSR would not supply arms to Pakistan in the event of war and opened the prospect of Moscow preoccupying Chinese troops along their border in the event of Beijing's intervention. Kaul argued that the treaty did 'not conflict with our conceptions of Non-alignment'. [10] Meanwhile, India's chargé d'affaires in Beijing, Brajesh Mishra, assessed that while China would continue to supply arms and support Pakistan at the UN, it would not intervene in a war between India and Pakistan. In addition to Chinese concerns about the Indo-Soviet Treaty, the People's Liberation Army was undergoing a significant political purge. [11]